

Black Women's Geographies: Interview Protocol

Project Explanation:

Black feminist geographies refer to the way that the intersectional identity of Black womanhood influences how we experience our communities, navigate different spaces, and interact with the world.

This is a digital mapping project intended to locate and visualize the geographic perspectives and experiences of Black women in Cambridge, MA. Through contextual interviews with Black women, we will gather information about their residential communities, social spaces, and daily activity locations.

This study will use a semi-structured interview format. The researcher accompanies the participant on a 30–45-minute walk around the participant's residency or typical activity space(s). The places, sentiments, and information expressed in these interviews will be used alongside recorded GPS routes of the walk to create a digital map of the City of Cambridge as it is interpreted through Black women's geographies.

Interview Protocol:

During the interview/walk, the researcher will ask each of the five questions below, allowing the participant to largely determine the direction of the conversation. When appropriate or necessary, the researcher will provide the next pre-written question or interject with a follow-up.

With participant consent, the interview audio will be recorded for later transcription and analysis. After analysis, participants will be provided with a copy of the audio, and the researcher's copy will be deleted. The route of the walk will also be recorded via cell phone GPS to facilitate the mapping process.

Informed Consent & Opening Script:

Like we've talked about before, today I will be walking around your neighborhood with you while you tell me what it is like to live in Cambridge and about your experiences in the city.

Your personal information, including name, age, and address, will not be recorded or stored. For data, though, I will need to track the route we take on my phone. ***Do you consent to my tracking this route?***

I would also like to record this interview to look at later in the research process. After we use the recording, we will delete our copy and send you one for your records. ***Do you consent to your voice being recorded during this interview?***

Questions:

1. How long have you lived in Cambridge?
2. Why did you come to Cambridge? Why have you stayed?
3. Are there any places you avoid in Cambridge as a Black woman? Why?
4. Where in Cambridge do you feel most like yourself?
5. What does it mean, to you, to be a Black woman in Cambridge?

Closing Script:

Thank you so much for letting me walk with you today.

I've asked all the questions from my scripts, but before I leave, do you want to say more about anything you've mentioned or share any last thoughts?

Thank you again.